RetroFE VLC

The Ultimate Visual Guide to Your Retro Gaming Frontend

1. QUICK START INSTALATION

Step 1:
Download & Extract
Get the last version of RetroFeVLC and Extract the archive to youe desired location (e.g., E:\RetroFeVLC.

Step 2:
Configure Settings
Edit the settingfs.conf file to set option like theme(layout).

Step 3:
Map Controls
Edit controls.conf and omcontrols.conf to map your keyboard and gamepad for menu naviagtion.

Step 4:
Add Addons
Like start.exe, and any other addons you wish to use.

Step 5:
Test & Add Games
Run the RetroFE - x64.ink shortcut our start.exe to test the frontend, then begin adding your own game collection.

\corex64
Is the brain of your setup retrofe.exe

2. ANATOMY OF RETROFE VLC: KEY FILES & FOLDERS

\collections
The heart of your setup Each subfolder represents a game system (e.g. Sega Genesis").

\layouts
Contains all your themes. Each theme defines the visual appearance.

\launchers.windows
Launchers are simple configurations that tell frontend how tro run any emulator

meta.db
The central database storing all metadata of your build.

3. BUILDING YOUR LIBRARY: THE COLLECTION SYSTEM

Menu Hierarchy
Create menus tree From MAIN (e.g. CONSOLES - SEGA GENESIS - GENESIS GAMELIST

Game Lists
Display a list of games for a specific system from your Roms folder

Favorites Collections
Create powerful, custom collections, display a subset of games from one or more other collections into a single menu (e.g. "Street Fighter Collection").

4. THE POWER OF ADDONS

Start (start.exe),
is the central nervous system of your entire setup. (e.g.. it will synchronize the playlists).

Search
Provides a lightning-fast, integrated game searching with a gamepad interface

MenuManager
A visual drag-and-drop tool simple Reorganize your entire menu by simply dragging items around

Metadata Regenerator
Creates customizing smaller metadata files from large ones perfect for themed collections and display game count statics.

Marquee MonitorDuplicator
Mirror any portion of your main gameplay screen onto the marquee monitor.

KioskMode
Locks down the Windows shell turning your PC into a dedicated and secure arcade machine

5. NEXT-LEVEL FEATURES OF RETROFE VLC

In-App Options Menu
Configure system settingfs and customize layouts options on-the-fly directly from the frontend

Enchanced Layout Engine
Create advanced themes with grid, menus, per-games layouts.
Add slideshows, animated gifs.
Advanced Rendering:
vSync, scale Quality, Lauout Scale.

Grid

Modular Layouts

Game Statistics Display
Display dynamic data like:
Number times play a game,
Last time played.

3D & Warp Effects

Per-Game Layouts

RetroFeVLC Comprehensive User Guide

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1. Getting Started

This section provides a detailed guide to installing and performing the initial configuration of RetroFeVLC on Windows systems.

1.1. Quick Start Steps

Video: https://youtu.be/FUBS3rJ8uuA

1 - https://retrofevlc.eu/
2 - Download last version (FUll)
3 - Join Discord
4 - Inside Discord Community:
4.1 - Update RetroFeVLC Base
4.2 - Download Launchers examples
4.3 - Read announcements to get last news and you can update your build
5 - Execute Start.exe
6 - Right Click Start System Tray icon
6.1 RetroFeVLC Options - Settings Editor - Layout tab - layout - Pheonix Lite
7 - System Tray Launch RetroFeVLC
8 - Discord Community - Themes Links - Download Phoenix (Full version - is a WIP)
9 - Config all to your needs, add your Games and enjoy !!

1.2. Detailed Installation

For Windows Users

Installation on Windows is typically a simple extraction process. After downloading the RetroFeVLC package, copy its contents to a directory of your choice. The frontend is ready for a first test by running the `retrofe.exe` executable located in the `/corex64/` directory, or by using the RetroFeVLC - x64.ink shortcut in the root. The default package includes a pre-installed Sega Genesis and Nintendo Entertainment System collection with

one virtual game (zero bits), which allows you to confirm that the installation was successful and the frontend is operational.

1.3. Initial Configuration

The first step after installation is to configure the core behavior of the frontend. This is done through two primary files in the root directory our Start GUI(Settings Editor):

- **settings.conf:** This is the global configuration file. Here you will set up essential parameters such as screen resolution (RetroFeVLC already supports auto config displays), fullscreen mode, the default theme (layout), and base paths for your ROMs and media if they are stored outside the main RetroFeVLC folder.
- **controls.conf:** This file is for mapping input devices. You define which keyboard keys, joystick buttons, or mouse clicks correspond to frontend actions like navigating menus (up, down, left, right) and making selections (select, back).

2. Directory Structure

A deep understanding of the RetroFeVLC directory structure is crucial for effective customization. The root folder contains several key files and subdirectories.

2.1. Root Files and Folders

File / Folder	Description
controls.conf	Controller configuration (up, down, select, back, etc.).
log.txt	Log output for troubleshooting. This is the first place to look if something goes wrong.
meta.db	The SQLite database that stores all game metadata (year, manufacturer, genre, etc.).
settings.conf	Global frontend settings (display options, layout to use, base paths, etc.).
/collections/	The heart of your setup. Contains subdirectories for each game system or menu.
/collections/MAIN/	Default start collection
/corex64/	Contains the main RetroFeVLC executable and necessary libraries (primarily for Windows).
/launchers/	Configuration files that tell RetroFeVLC how to launch emulators.
/layouts/	Contains all themes (layouts) that define the visual appearance of the frontend.
/meta/	A directory for storing raw metadata files (e.g., HyperSpin XML, MAME DATs) before they are imported into meta.db.
/emulators/	Optional (users decide what folder name want to use)
/settings/	Needed if using the Addons.
/settings/TOOLS/	Needed if using Addons (e.g KioskMode, MenuManager, MetaDataRegenerator, SuperF4, JoyToKey), and others.
/settings/SEARCH/	Needed if using the Addon.

2.2. Collection Directory Structure

Each folder inside /collections/ represents a single collection (e.g., a system or a menu) and has its own internal structure:

File / Folder	Description
settings.conf	Collection-specific settings that can override global ones (e.g., ROM extensions, launcher).
info.conf	Optional file to store system-level information like manufacturer, year, and generation.
/info/gameName.conf	Optional file to store Game-level information like manufacturer, year, and generation.
menu.txt	For menu collections, this file lists the names of other collections to display as a submenu.
/menu/	For menu collections, can be done using menu folder plus collectionNames.txt files
include.txt / exclude.txt	Text files listing games to explicitly include or exclude from the collection's list.
<collectionname>.sub	Used for sub/merged collections to import game lists from other collections.
/roms/	Default location to store the ROM/game files for this collection.
/playlists/	Directory for playlist files (e.g., favorites.txt, genre_action.txt).
/medium_artwork/	Contains artwork for individual games, organized into subfolders like artwork_front, screenshot, video, etc.
/system_artwork/	Contains artwork for the collection itself, such as a picture of the console (device.png) or its logo (logo.png).

3. Updates

3.1. Website

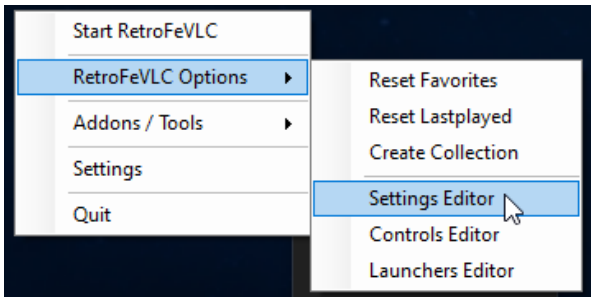
- Enter Website subscribe to Discord RetroFeVLC https://retrofevlc.eu

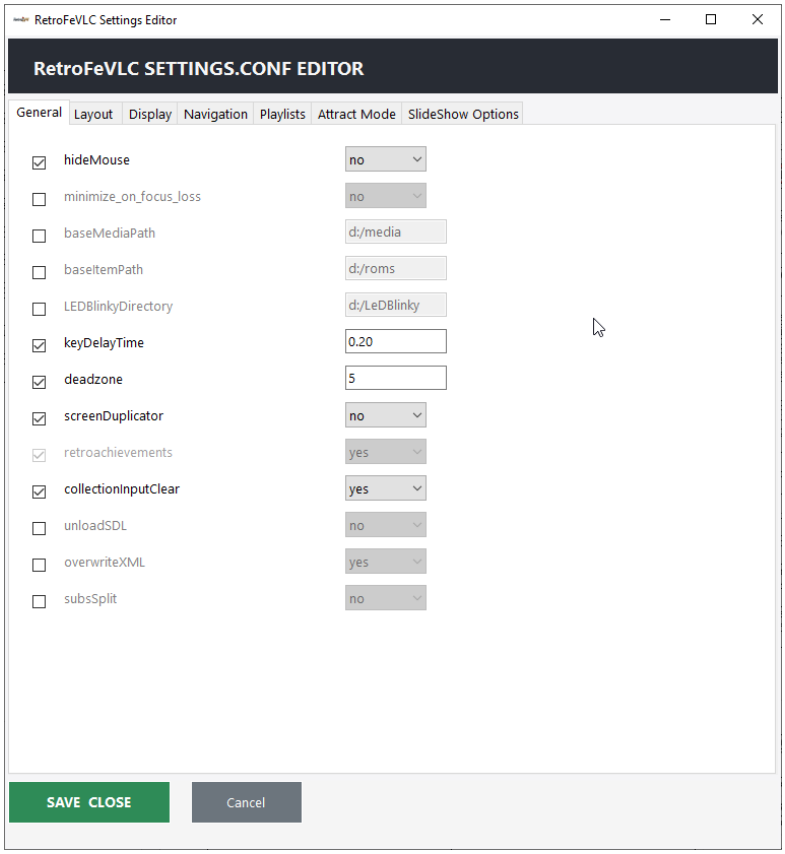
3.2. Download Updates

- Start and RetroFeVLC overwrite existent ones

- Download New Addons and existing Updates

4. Global Settings (settings.conf) using Settings Editor





The global settings.conf file governs the core functionality of RetroFeVLC. Below is a comprehensive list of available parameters.

4.1. Display Options

Variable	Allowed values	Description
numScreens	1+	Defines the number of monitors used. Defaults to 1. If commented/deleted, auto-detects horizontal, vertical, fullscreen.(VLC)
fullscreen	yes, true, no, false	Run the front-end in fullscreen.
Horizontal / vertical	stretch, #pixels	Screen pixel width and height (e.g., 1920, 1080).
fullscreenX	yes, true, no, false	Run in fullscreen on a specific monitor X (e.g., fullscreen0 = no). Monitors start at 0.
5orizontal / verticalX	stretch, #pixels	Screen dimensions for a specific monitor X.
rotationX	0, 1, 2, 3	Rotation for monitor X (in 90-degree angles).
mirrorX	yes, true, no, false	Mirror mode for monitor X, dividing the screen and mirroring the image.
windowBorder	yes, true, no, false	Show the window border in windowed mode.
windowResize	yes, true, no, false	Allow the window to be resized.

vSync (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	Waits for monitor refresh before presenting frames, ensuring smoother visuals.
scaleQuality (VLC)	auto, 0, 1, 2	Render scale quality: 0 (nearest, default), 1 (linear), 2 (anisotropic).
4kPreScaleQuality (VLC)	off, fast, smooth	Pre-scaling for 4K textures. `fast` is lower quality, `smooth` is higher quality but more resource-intensive.
enableReflectionsFor4KX (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	Enables reflections for 4K textures (≥3840x2160). Defaults to true. Specific monitor X.
layoutScaleModeX (VLC)	none, fit, fill, stretch	Controls how the layout is scaled to fit different monitor resolutions. Specific monitor X.
layoutZoomModeX (VLC)	> 0	Acts as a zoom factor for the layout. >1.0 enlarges, <1.0 shrinks. Specific monitor X.
marqueePauseScreenX (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	If false (default), animations on screen X (e.g., a marquee) keep running when the main screen is paused.
enableScreenX (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	Disables secondary screens to prevent creating an SDL window for them. Monitor 0 cannot be disabled.

4.2. UI and Navigation

Variable	Allowed values	Description
layout	A folder name in /layouts	The layout/theme to use for RetroFeVLC (e.g., Aeon Nox).
fps	Frames per second (positive)	Requested FPS while not in the idle state. Defaults to 60.
fpsIdle	frames per second (positive)	Requested FPS while in the idle state. Defaults to 60.
hideMouse	yes, true, no, false	Hide the mouse cursor when the FE is active.
showParenthesis	yes, true, no, false	Hide item/ROM information between ()
showSquareBrackets	yes, true, no, false	Hide item/ROM information between []
firstCollection	A folder name in /collections/	Specify the name of the first collection to load on start (e.g., Main).
rememberMenu	yes, true, no, false	Remember the last highlighted menu item if re-entering a menu.
exitOnFirstPageBack	yes, true, no, false	Exit the frontend when the back button is pressed on the first page.
enterOnCollection	yes, true, no, false	Enter the collection when using collectionUp/Down controls.
startCollectionEnter	yes, true, no, false	Enter the first collection on RetroFeVLC boot.
startMainBuild	A folder name in /collections/	If not Main, info for Auto Navigation will know what's the 1st collection
cfwLetterSub	yes, true, no, false	If subs exist in a collection, jump those subs by sub instead of by letter (CoinOPS feature)
prevLetterSubToCurrent	yes, true, no, false	When using previous letter control, it will jump to the start of the current

		letter instead of the start of the previous one
jumpNextBack (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	Controls whether RetroFeVLC automatically enters and exits a subcollection to force loading its artwork when `startCollectionEnter = no`.
collectionInputClear	yes, true, no, false	Clear the input queue when entering/exiting a collection
jumpInputClear	yes, true, no, false	Clear the input queue when jumping through the menu
videoEnable	yes, true, no, false	Enable video display
videoLoop	#loops	Number of times to loop video playback (enter 0 to continuously loop)
screenDuplicator (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	If using the Addon, Mirror display1 to Marquee support more than one instance

4.3. Attract Mode

Variable	Allowed values	Description
attractModeTime	Time (in seconds)	Enter 0 to disable attract mode, otherwise enter the number of seconds to wait before it starts.
attractModeNextTime	Time (in seconds)	Time before the menu scrolls to another random point while already in attract mode.
attractModePlaylistTime	Time (in seconds)	Enter the number of seconds before the menu switches to the next playlist. Enter 0 to disable (default).
attractModeCollectionTime	Time (in seconds)	Enter the number of seconds before the menu switches to the next collection. Enter 0 to disable (default).
attractModeSkipPlaylist	playlist name	Skip this collection while switching collections in attract mode.
attractModeSkipCollection	playlist name	Skip this collection while switching collections in attract mode.
attractModeMinTime	Time (in ms)	Minimum time attract mode will scroll (default 0 ms)
attractModeMaxTime	Time (in ms)	Maximum time attract mode will scroll (default 5000 ms)
attractModeCyclePlaylist	yes, true, no, false	Select between cycling through the full set of playlists or the ones defined in the cyclePlaylist

4.4. Playlists

Variable	Allowed values	Description
firstPlaylist	Playlist name	Automatically switch to this playlist if it is available (e.g., favorites).
playlistInputClear	yes, true, no, false	Clear the input queue when changing playlist
lastplayedSize	Size (natural)	Size of the automatically generated lastplayed playlist. 0 disables this feature.
lastPlayedSkipCollection	Collection name	Do not include items from this collection in the lastplayed playlist.
cyclePlaylist	Playlist set	Comma-separated set of playlists that the playlist cycle keys cycle through.
lastplayedByLastAccess (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	`yes`: Last-access order, `no`: Alphabetical for last-played playlist.
favoritesByLastAccess (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	`yes`: Last-access order, `no`: Alphabetical (except FAVORITES collection).
favoritesCollectionByAsc (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	`yes`: Alphabetical, `no`: Last-access order for FAVORITES collection.
sizeFileName (VLC)	filename.txt	Specifies file for storing game count info displayed in the menu.

4.5. Advanced/System

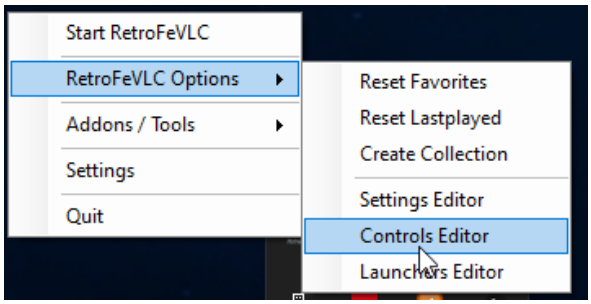
Variable	Allowed values	Description
baseMediaPath	i.e.(d:/media)	Override if you choose to have your media stored outside of RetroFE. Can be used by your Collection Settings.conf.
baseItemPath	i.e.(d:/roms)	Override if you choose to have your roms stored outside of RetroFE. Can be used by your Collection Settings.conf.
unloadSDL	yes, true, no, false	Close SDL when starting a game. Needed for some systems like RetroPie.
overwriteXML	yes, true, no, false	Allow `info.conf` files to overwrite information from `meta.db`.
subsSplit	yes, true, no, false	Split merged collections based on `.sub` files (`yes`) or sort them as one list (`no`).
LEDBlinkyDirectory	LEDBlinky installation directory	Setting this directory will enable LEDBlinky support.
minimize_on_focus_loss	yes, true, no, false	Overwrite system SDL default for SDL_VIDEO_MINIMIZE_ON_FOCUS_LOSS to force RetroFeVLC to (not)

		minimize when the focus on the full-screen window is lost.
preloadAhead (VLC)	>1 (default = 10)	It loads a few more items below what you're looking at.
preloadBehind (VLC)	>1 (default = 10)	It loads a few more items below what you're looking at.
screenDuplicator (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	Mirror display1 to Marquee to support more than one instance.
Retroachievements (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	Wen RetroRa is logged it auto active
retroachievementsCollection (VLC)	true, false, yes, no	If usder want that retroachievements collection auto update

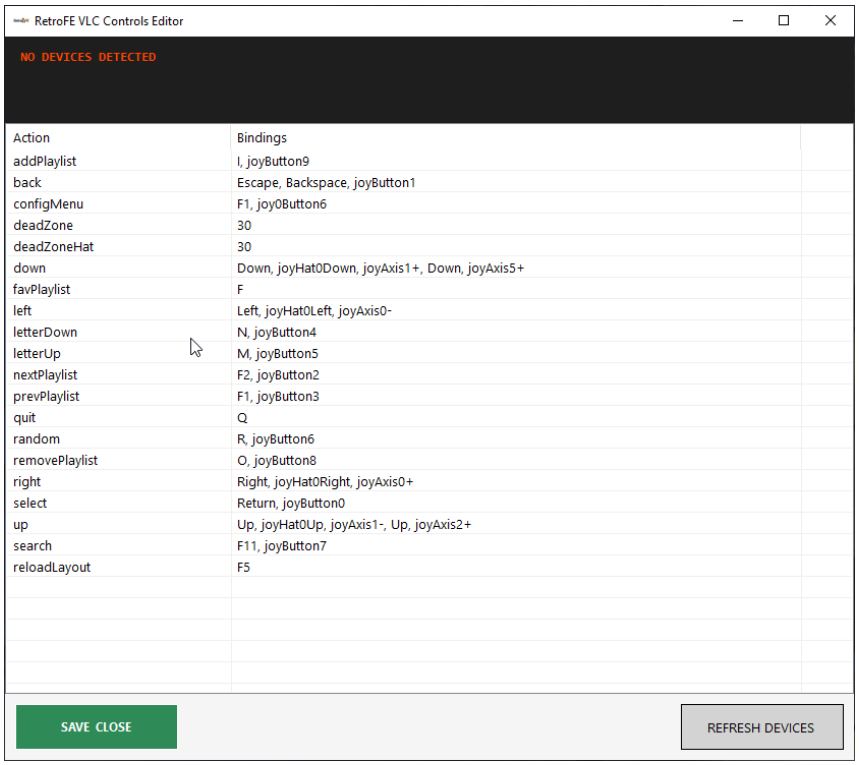
4.6 Random / Slides (VLC)

Variable	Allowed values	Description
maxRandomMedia	1+	Maximum images/videos to collect for random slideshows (default: 100).
maxSubcollections	1+	Maximum sub-collections to sample for random modes (default: 5).
slideShowTimer	Time (in seconds)	Default time between slides in a slideshow. Can be overridden by the layout.
randomSyncMedia	true, false, yes, no	Syncs <reloadableImage> with <reloadableVideo> for random=true, excluding slideShow (layouts).
randomSyncSlide	true, false, yes, no	Syncs <reloadableImage> with <reloadableVideo> for random=true when slideShow is active (layouts).

5. Controls (controls.con)



The controls.conf file maps all user inputs. Multiple keys can be assigned to a single action, separated by a comma (e.g., Up = Keypad 8, Up).



5.1. Control Actions

Control	Description
up / down / left / right	Scrolls menu in the respective direction.
pageUp / pageDown	Scrolls menu back/forward by a page.
letterUp / letterDown	Scrolls to the previous/next item in the alphabet.
collectionUp / collectionDown	Scrolls to the previous/next collection.
addPlaylist / removePlaylist	Adds/Removes a game from the favorites playlist.
favPlaylist	Switches to the favorites playlist.
nextPlaylist / prevPlaylist	Switches to the next/previous playlist.
nextCyclePlaylist / prevCyclePlaylist	Switches to the next/previous playlist in the `cyclePlaylist` set.
random	Selects a random game.
select	Selects the active menu item.
back	Leaves the current menu.
quit	Exits the frontend.
Search (VLC)	Opens the Options Menu (Default: F1).
reloadLayout (VLC)	Reloads the current layout (Default: F5).
deadZone	Defines the dead zone for analog inputs.
keyDelayTime (VLC)	Delay (in seconds) before repeating the same direction input while holding the button/stick (affects menu scrolling speed) Possible values: - 0.0 or 0 → disabled: continuous scrolling while holding (fastest) - 0.08–0.12 → very responsive (arcade / fightstick style)

	- 0.15–0.25 → fast but controlled (good compromise for most gamepads) - 0.30 → default / more forgiving - 0.40–0.60 → slow, prevents accidental double moves

5.2. Input Keycodes

Gamepad/Joystick Codes

Keycode	Description
joyXButtonY	Gamepad button (X=joypad number, Y=button number).
joyXHatY[Direction]	Gamepad hat direction (e.g., joy0Hat0LeftUp).
joyXAxisZ[+/-]	Analog stick axis direction (e.g., joy0Axis1-).

If X is omitted (e.g., joyButton0), RetroFeVLC will accept input from all controllers (v0.8.13+).

Mouse Codes

Keycode	Description
mouseButtonLeft / mouseButtonMiddle / mouseButtonRight	The respective mouse buttons.

Keyboard Codes

RetroFeVLC supports a comprehensive set of keyboard codes. This includes standard alphanumeric keys (A, B, 1, 2), function keys (F1 - F24), navigation keys (Up, Down, Home, End), keypad keys (Keypad 1, Keypad +), modifier keys (Left Shift, Right Alt), and special keys (Return, Escape, Backspace, Tab, Space). For a complete list of all possible keycodes, refer to the official SDL scancode documentation, as RetroFeVLC's naming convention is based on it.

6. Collections

Collections are the fundamental organizational unit in RetroFeVLC, defining lists of games or other menus.

6.1. Types of Collections

1. (Sub-)Menu Collections: These create a hierarchical menu. A menu.txt file our menu/ folder within the collection's folder lists the names of other collections, which will appear as items in a submenu. This allows for structures like Main → Consoles → Nintendo Entertainment System.

2. Game Collections: The most common type; these collections consist of a list of games for a specific system. The list is generated from the contents of the roms directory, optionally filtered by include.txt and exclude.txt files.

3. Sub/Merged Collections: These are powerful collections that display a subset of games from one or more other collections. For example, a "Street Fighter" collection could be

created by pulling all "Street Fighter" games from MAME, SNES, and Genesis collections. This is defined using one or more .sub files.

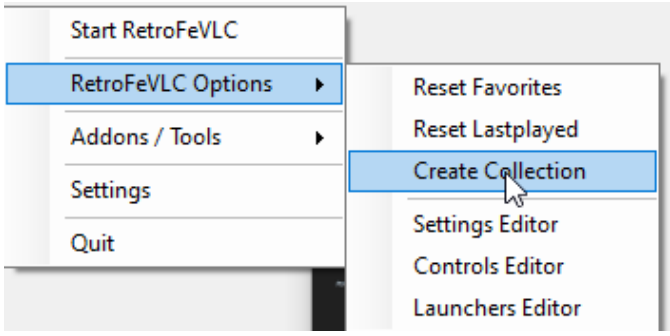
6.2. Default and Custom Collection Setup

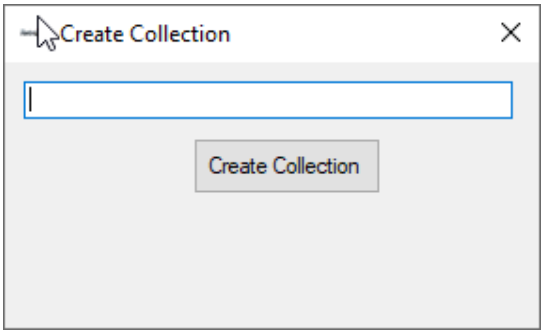
Upon initial installation, RetroFeVLC provides essential default folders to manage its core functionality:

- **_common**: This folder houses shared assets such as icons and artworks that are utilized across different categories, manufacturers, or systems.
- **Main**: This is the default collection folder, crucial for the primary menu's operation. It contains key configuration files, including menu.txt, which needs to be edited to enable newly created extra collections in the interface.

6.3. Creating and Adding a Collection

Let's walk through an example of setting up a Nintendo Entertainment System collection.
1. Create the Collection: From your RetroFeVLC root directory, run the command: # For Windows
core\retrofe.exe -createcollection "Nintendo Entertainment System" or start system tray icon RetroFeVLC Options-Create Collection - creates menu icon to collections\COLLECTIONS\menu\yourCollection.txt





2. Add ROMs and Artwork:
- Place your .nes ROMs in /collections/Nintendo Entertainment System/roms/.
- Place system artwork (console photo, logo) in /collections/Nintendo Entertainment System/system_artwork/.
- Place game-specific artwork (box art, screenshots) in /collections/Nintendo Entertainment System/medium_artwork/

3. Configure the Collection: Edit /collections/Nintendo Entertainment System/settings.conf. A minimal configuration is: list.extensions = nes , launcher = NES / launcher = %ITEM_COLLECTION_NAME% (same as Nintendo Entertainment System).

4. Configure the Launcher: Create a file named /launchers.windows/NES.conf conf / Nintendo Entertainment System.conf that tells RetroFeVLC how to run the emulator. For Nestopia, it might look like this: executable = D:\RetroFeVLC\Emulators\Nestopia\nestopia.exe
arguments = "%ITEM_FILEPATH%"

5. Add to Main Menu: Edit /collections/Main/menu.txt and add a new line with the exact collection name: Nintendo Entertainment System our menu folder /collections/Main/menu/Nintendo Entertainment System.txt

6.3. Directory Structure of a Collection

Each collection resides in its own dedicated folder within the collections directory and comprises a specific set of files and subfolders for configuration and content management:

File / Folder	Description
info.conf	Stores additional system information (manufacturer, year, generation) displayable in themes. Can also be set in settings.conf, but this file allows for cleaner separation.
include.txt	If populated, lists ROM filenames (without extension) to include. If empty, all ROMs in the roms folder are included.
exclude.txt	Lists ROM filenames (without extension) to exclude from the current collection's list.
exclude_all.txt	Lists ROM filenames (without extension) to exclude from all playlists.
settings.conf	Configures ROM file extensions, default launchers (emulators), override media paths, and other collection-specific settings.
<collectionname>.sub	A text file containing a list of games (one per line, without extension) imported from another collection. Useful for creating sub-collections or merged lists. If empty, it merges the entire referenced collection.
roms/	The default directory to search for ROM files. This path can be altered in settings.conf.
playlists/	Default location for playlist files (e.g., favorites.txt).
medium_artwork/	Subdirectories for individual game artwork (artwork_back, artwork_front, medium_back, medium_front, screenshot, screentitle, logo, video, story).
system_artwork/	Subdirectories and files for artwork specific to the collection itself (e.g., device.png, logo.png, video.mp4, story.txt).

6.4. Collection-Specific settings.conf

Variable	Description
list.path	Location of your ROMs for this collection. Can use variables like %BASE_ITEM_PATH%.
list.extensions	Comma-separated list of ROM file extensions (e.g., zip,nes).
list.includeMissingItems	If `true`, includes games from `include.txt` even if the ROM file doesn't exist.
list.menuSort	If `true`, sorts items in the collection alphabetically.
list.romHierarchy / list.truRIP	Defines whether the roms directory should be searched hierarchically. Incurs a performance hit.
launcher	Specifies which launcher from /launchers/ to use for this collection.
metadata.type	Specifies the meta file used in `meta.db` to pull additional information from.
list.autoPlaylist(VLC)	Automatically switch to this playlist if it is available.

6.5. In-Depth: (Sub-)Menu and Game Collections

(Sub-)Menu Collections:

These collections act as navigation hubs, pointing to other collections. They are primarily defined using a menu.txt(discontinued, evolved to the menu folder) file within the collection's directory. Each line in menu.txt should correspond to the name of another collection folder. For instance, a menu.txt file listing consoles like "Atari 2600", "MAME", and "Nintendo Entertainment System" implies that folders named collections/Atari 2600, collections/MAME, and collections/Nintendo Entertainment System must exist.

RetroFeVLC also supports legacy menu.xml files for backward compatibility, though menu.txt is significantly more concise.

It's possible to combine games and collections in a single menu by having both a menu.txt and a games collection present.

Games Collections:

These collections are designed to display actual games. They rely on the contents of the roms directory, filtered by include.txt and exclude.txt. The behavior depends on the list.includeMissingItems setting in settings.conf:

- If false: RetroFeVLC first reads all ROMs in the roms directory, then keeps only those listed in include.txt, and finally removes any listed in exclude.txt.
- If true: RetroFeVLC uses the list from include.txt as the primary source and then removes any entries listed in exclude.txt.

6.6. Advanced Features: Sub/Merged Collections and Playlists

Sub/Merged Collections:

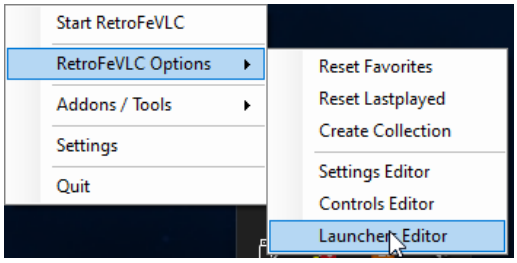
Sub collections allow you to create subsets of larger collections. For example, a "Capcom Play System III" collection could be a sub-collection of a "MAME" or "Arcade" collection. This is achieved by creating a <collectionname>.sub file (e.g., Capcom Play System III.sub) within the parent collection's directory. This .sub file simply lists the game names (without extensions) that belong to the sub-collection. Artwork and ROMs are then referenced from the parent collection.

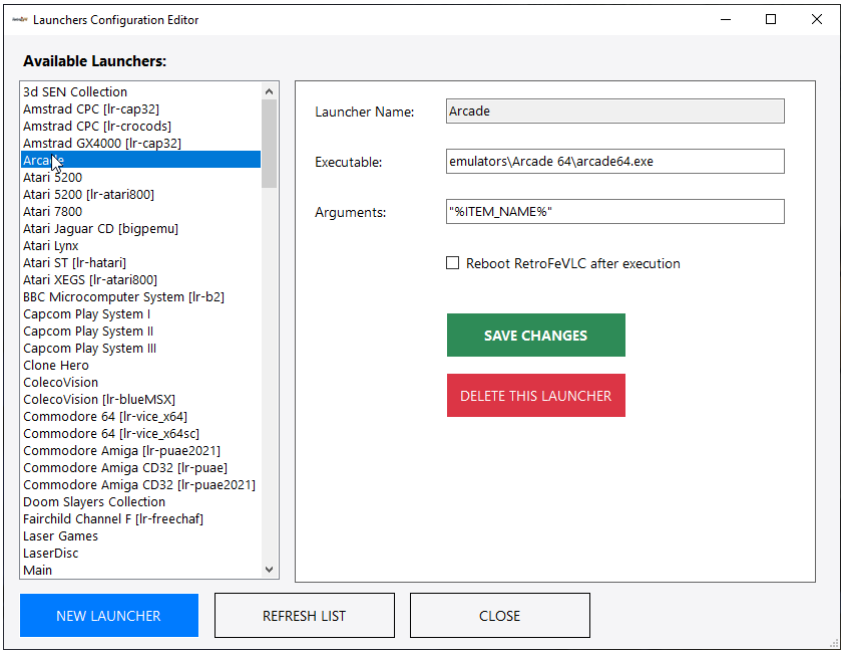
By using multiple .sub files (e.g., one for NES Contra games, another for SNES Contra games), you can create **merged collections** that consolidate specific games from various sources into a single list.

6.7. Playlists

Playlists act as filters within a collection. They are defined by .txt files in a collection's /playlists/ directory. Each file contains a list of game names (without extension) that belong to that playlist. A special playlist is favorites.txt, which can be modified in real-time from the frontend using the `addPlaylist` and `removePlaylist` controls.

7. Launchers





A launcher configuration file describes how to launch an external program (emulator, application, or game) when an item is selected.

7.1. Launcher Configuration

Each .conf file in the /launchers/ directory defines one launcher. The two main properties are executable and arguments.

```
# Example for Nestopia: /launchers/NES.conf
executable = D:\RetroFeVLC\Emulators\Nestopia\nestopia.exe
arguments = "\"%ITEM_FILEPATH%\""
```

Note the quotes around "%ITEM_FILEPATH%". This is crucial to handle filenames with spaces correctly.

7.2. Launcher Variables

These variables are replaced by RetroFeVLC at runtime to pass information to the emulator.

Variable	Description	Example
%ITEM_FILEPATH%	Full item path	D:/ROMs/Nintendo/Super Mario Bros.nes
%ITEM_NAME%	The item name	Super Mario Bros
%ITEM_FILENAME%	Filename without path	Super Mario Bros.nes
%ITEM_DIRECTORY%	Folder where file exists	D:/ROMs/Nintendo
%ITEM_COLLECTION_NAME%	Name of collection for item	Nintendo Entertainment System
%RETROFE_PATH%	Folder location of Frontend	D:/RetroFeVLC

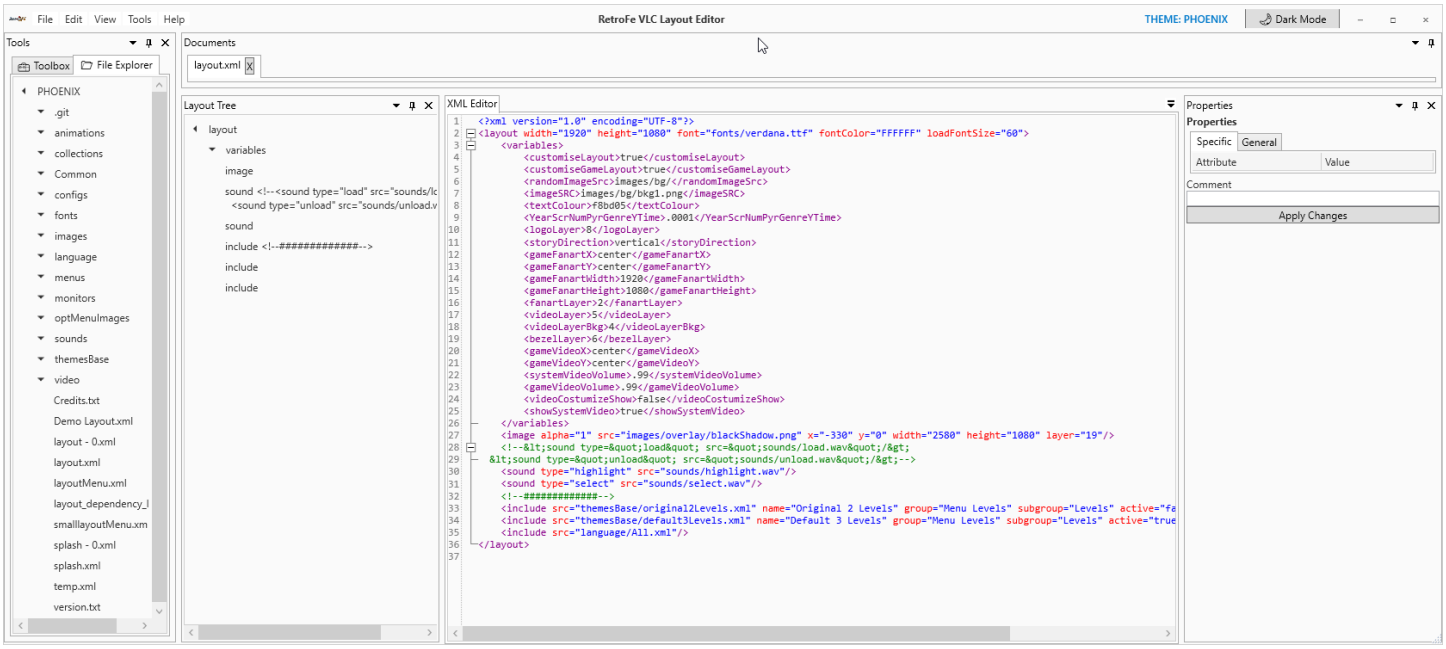
7.3. Advanced Launcher Example

You can create more complex launch commands, for example, to load a specific save state with a game.

```
# Have RetroArch load a save state automatically for the ROM when started
executable = emulators\RetroArch\retroarch.exe
arguments = -L cores\fmsx_libretro.dll --appendconfig "config\_System\Microsoft MSX\SYSTEM.cfg" --state "states\Microsoft MSX\%ITEM_NAME%.state" "%ITEM_FILEPATH%"
```

8. Layouts (*"for advanced users – changes may break your build".)*

I won't go into the subject because this guide is not about layouts.



(Layout Editor)

Layouts define the entire visual experience of RetroFeVLC. They are constructed using XML files and a rich set of components and parameters.

A layout generally consists of the following structure:

```
<layout>
 <sound/>
 <menu/>
 <video/>
 <image/>
 <text/>
 <reloadableAudio/>
 <reloadableVideo/>
 <reloadableImage/>
 <reloadableText/>
 <reloadableScrollingText/>
</layout>
```

8.1. Core Layout Structure

```
<layout width="1920" height="1080" font="Roboto-Bold.ttf">
    <!-- Static elements -->
    <image src="background.png" />
    <text value="My Awesome Setup" />

    <!-- Dynamic elements that update on selection -->

    <variables></variables>
    <include src="path"/>
    <reloadableImage type="logo" mode="system" />
    <reloadableVideo type="video" />
    <reloadableText type="year" />

    <!-- The main menu list -->
    <menu type="vertical">
        ...
    </menu>
</layout>
```

8.2. General Layout Information

- **Directory Structure:** Each layout is a folder in /layouts/ containing at least a layout.xml. A splash.xml can be added for a startup screen.
- **Layout Overrides:** RetroFeVLC uses a powerful override system, searching for layout files in a specific order (per-monitor, per-ratio, then default). It also allows for per-collection and even per-game layouts.
-
- **Layout Include:** supports split xml files eg. (<include src="ButtomBar/all.xml"/> - source always from layout.xml root (VLC)
- **Layout variables:** supports variables (supports nest variables in split files and "${randomImageSrc}bkg1.jpg" (VLC)
-
- **Per-Game Layouts:** A key feature of RetroFeVLC VLC is the ability to create a unique layout for a single game by naming an XML file after it (e.g., Super Metroid.xml) in the collection's layout directory. This creates a dedicated page for that game, it accepts default.xml that creates to all games.

9. Metadata

RetroFeVLC uses a central database, meta.db, to store rich information about games. This database is populated from files you place in the /meta/ directory.
Important: The metadata system is used to **add information** to the game lists that RetroFeVLC generates from your roms folders. It does not create the game lists themselves.

9.1. Supported Metadata Formats

- **HyperSpin XML:** Place HyperSpin database XML files in /meta/hyperlist/. RetroFeVLC reads tags like <description>, <manufacturer>, <year>, <genre>, etc.
-
- **truRIP (super)dat files:** Place DAT files in /meta/trurip/.
-
- **MAME XML:** Place MAME's -listxml output in /meta/mamelist/.

9.2. Overwriting Metadata

You can add or override information for a specific game by creating a .conf file in /collections/<collection_name>/info/<item_name>.conf. For this to work, you must set overwriteXML = yes in your global settings.conf.

```
# Example: /collections/MAME/info/mslug.conf
manufacturer = Nazca Corporation
year = 1996
```

10. RetroFeVLC VLC Features

The "RetroFeVLC VLC" version introduces a host of powerful new features, significantly enhancing customization and performance. Many of these have been integrated into the sections above, but this section provides a focused overview.

- **Advanced Display Control:** New settings like vSync, scaleQuality, and layoutScaleMode offer *fine-tuned* control over rendering.
-
- **Enhanced Layout Engine:**
  - **Grid Menus:** A new <menu type="Grid"> for creating 2D grid-based navigation.
  -
  - **Per-Game Layouts:** The ability to create a unique [GameName].xml layout for individual games.
  -
  - **Slideshows & Randomization:** Powerful random and slideShow attributes for images and videos.
  -
  - **Animated Image Support:** Control GIF animations with frameLoop and speed attributes.
  -
  - **3D & Warp Effects:** Animate elements in 3D space with flip3DX/Y and roller3DX/Y, or apply perspective distortion with wrap attributes.
  -
  - **Modular Layouts:** Split layouts into multiple files using <include> and define reusable values with <variables>.
-
- **Game Statistics:** New reloadableText types like playCount, totalPlayTime, and topgamename allow you to display usage statistics directly in your theme.
-
- **In-App Options Menu:** A built-in menu (accessed with F1) to configure RetroFeVLC settings and layout options without manually editing files.

10.1 RetroFeVLC ADDONS

The RetroFeVLC ecosystem is enhanced by a suite of powerful addons designed to streamline the user experience, automate complex tasks, and unlock new functionalities. These tools work in concert to create a seamless and highly customizable retro gaming environment. This guide provides a detailed overview of the core addons, their features, and configuration.

The following addons will be covered in this section:

- Launcher (start.exe)
- Search
- MenuManager
- Metadata ReGenerator
- GenreFixer
- KioskMode

- Story Translator
- Layout Tree Maker
- Layout Editor
- RetroRa Sync – RetroAchievements Sync
- Marquee MonitorDuplicator

10.1.1 Start: RetroFeVLC Starter (start.exe)

The RetroFeVLC Starter, or start.exe, is the central nervous system of your entire setup. It acts as an intelligent, one-click launcher that automates a series of critical pre-flight checks and background processes. By simply executing this program (either manually or on system startup), you ensure that your RetroFeVLC environment launches perfectly every time, with all components correctly configured and synchronized.

Key Features and Automation
The Starter handles several essential tasks automatically upon launch:

1. **Seamless Controller Support:** The Starter automatically initializes JoyToKey (if installed in \settings\TOOLS\joytokey\) with your pre-configured profile. This ensures that your arcade stick, gamepad, or other controllers are immediately recognized not only by the Windows environment but also by every emulator you launch, providing a true console-like experience from the very first second.

2. **System Stability Safety Net:** If you have SuperF4 installed (in \settings\TOOLS\SuperF4\), the Starter will launch it in the background. This provides a robust terminate application, avoiding the need to access the Task Manager and disrupt the gaming experience.

3. **Dynamic start/close programs:** User has 3 options to launch his own programs wen RetroFeVLC is launch, auto closes on close.

4. **Real-Time Playlist Synchronization:** The Starter guarantees that your "Favorites" and "Last Played" lists are always 100% in sync. Regardless of which game collection you are browsing or playing from, any game you add to your favorites or recently play is instantly updated in the master lists, which are then reflected across the entire frontend.

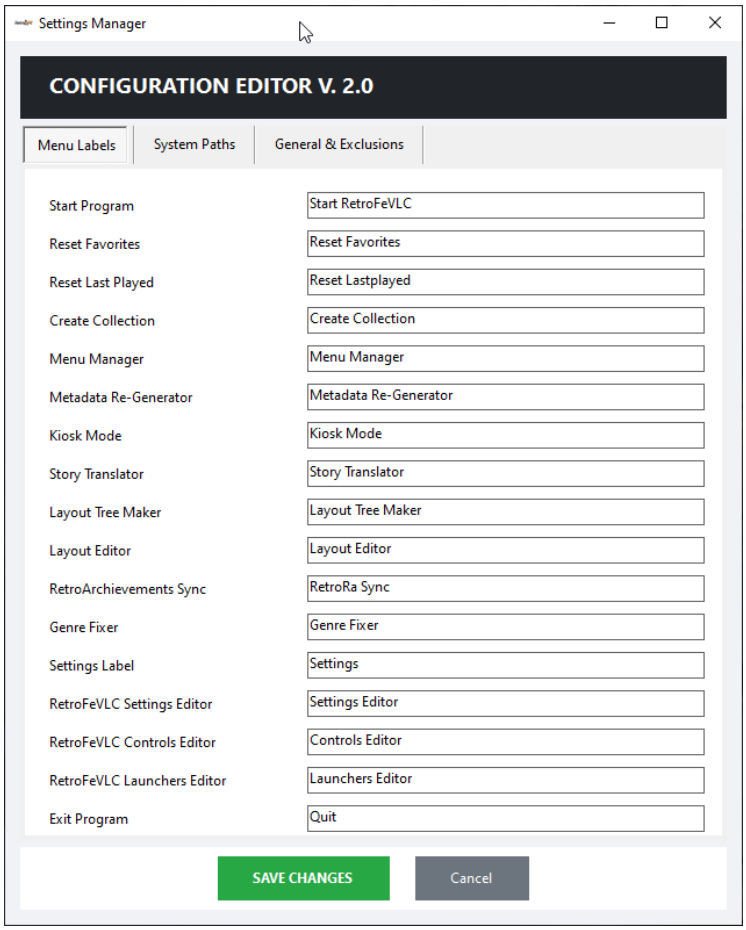
5. **Automatic Playlist Cleaning:** To maintain a clean and focused user interface, the Starter can be configured to monitor and automatically delete unwanted playlist folders. If you don't want system-level collections like "CONSOLES" or "PC GAMES" cluttering your global "Favorites" list, the Starter will silently remove these folders the moment they are created by the frontend.

6. **System Tray Superpowers:** The Starter runs as a lightweight icon in the system tray, providing quick access to essential management functions. A simple right-click on the icon reveals a context menu with powerful shortcuts:

    - **Start RetroFeVLC:** Manually launch the frontend.
    - RetroFeVLC Options
    - **Reset Favorites:** Clear these lists to start fresh.
    - **Reset LastPlayed**
    - **Create new collections:** A shortcut to initiate the favorites (GameName) collection creation process.

- **Settings Editor**
- **Controls Editor**
- **Launchers Editor**
  - Addons / Tools
- **Menu Manager:** Instantly open MenuManager or the Metadata Re-Generator.
- **Metadata Regenerator:** Fix big metadat.xml lists to correct existed games
- **GenreFixer:** Fixes the Genres from the Metadata File (eg. Game Serie (Contra same Genre to all)
- **KioskMode:** Easily enable or disable Kiosk Mode.
- **Story Translator:** Translates games story's gamename.txt
- **Layout Tree Maker:** It's more a Layout Files Manager / Variables Manager option to Merge.
- **Layout Editor:** Layout Maker / Editor
- **RetroRa Sync:** RetroAchievements Synchronizer
  - **Settings:** Manages Start Settings.

Quit: Cleanly shut down the Starter and associated background processes.



Configuration GUI Settings(Start.json)

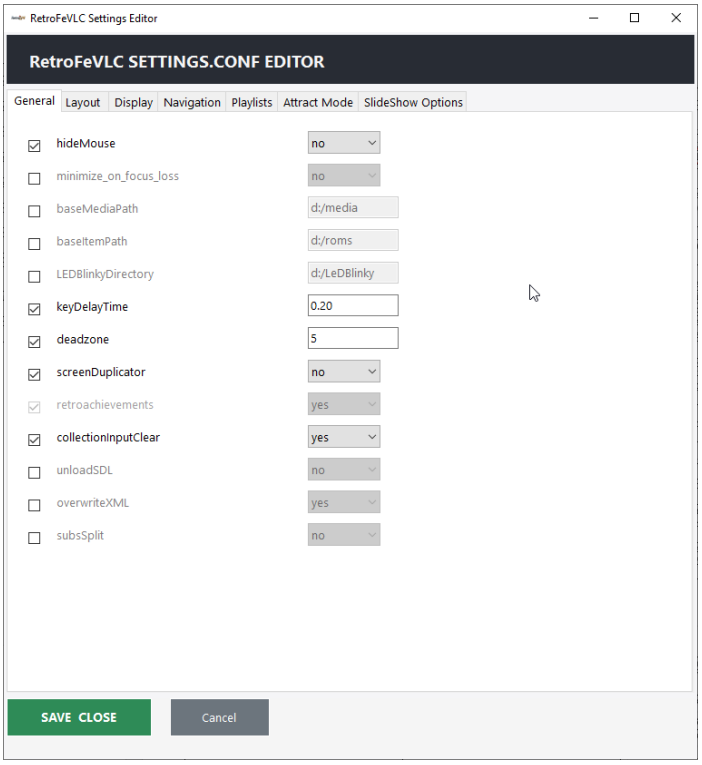
The behavior of the Starter is controlled by a Start.json file located in the same directory. Using Graphic User Interface allows you to customize nearly every aspect of its operation. Below is an example configuration followed by a detailed explanation of each parameter.

Configuration Parameter Reference

Parameter	Description
IsSystemTraySupported	Set to true to enable the system tray icon and its context menu.
OnStartLaunchRetroFe	If true, RetroFE/RetroFeVLC will be launched automatically as soon as the Starter application is run. If using KioskMode active this first.
Menu*	These string values (e.g., MenuStartProgram, MenuExitProgram) define the text labels that appear in the system tray context menu for each action (can use Translations).
PlayListsSize	Defines the maximum number of entries to keep in dynamic playlists like "Last Played".
HyperListFolder	Specifies the relative path to the folder containing your metadata XML files (hyperlists).
CollectionsRoot	The root directory where all your game collections are stored.
FavoritesCollectionsFolder	The sub-directory within a collection where favorite lists are stored.
FavoritesFolder	The name of the master "Favorites" folder.
LastPlayedFolder	The name of the master "Last Played" folder.
AllGamesFolder	The name of the master "All Games" folder.
ExcludedFolders	An array of folder names that will be automatically removed from playlists like "Favorites" to prevent clutter. This is case-insensitive.

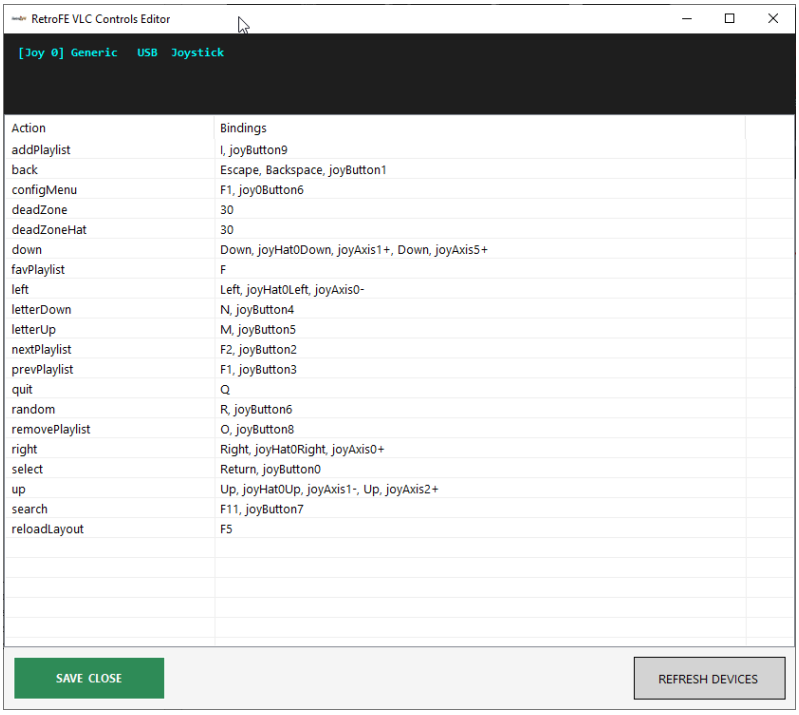
Settings Editor

Graphic User Interface to manage all RetroFeVLC Settings



By: RFSVIEIRA

Controls Editor



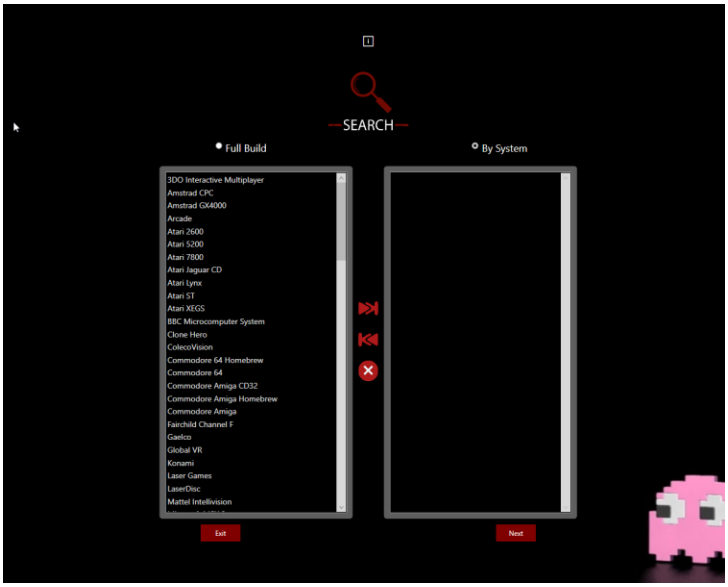
Action	Bindings
addPlaylist	I, joyButton9
back	Escape, Backspace, joyButton1
configMenu	F1, joy0Button6
deadZone	30
deadZoneHat	30
down	Down, joyHat0Down, joyAxis1+, Down, joyAxis5+
favPlaylist	F
left	Left, joyHat0Left, joyAxis0-
letterDown	N, joyButton4
letterUp	M, joyButton5
nextPlaylist	F2, joyButton2
prevPlaylist	F1, joyButton3
quit	Q
random	R, joyButton6
removePlaylist	O, joyButton8
right	Right, joyHat0Right, joyAxis0+
select	Return, joyButton0
up	Up, joyHat0Up, joyAxis1-, Up, joyAxis2+
search	F11, joyButton7
reloadLayout	F5

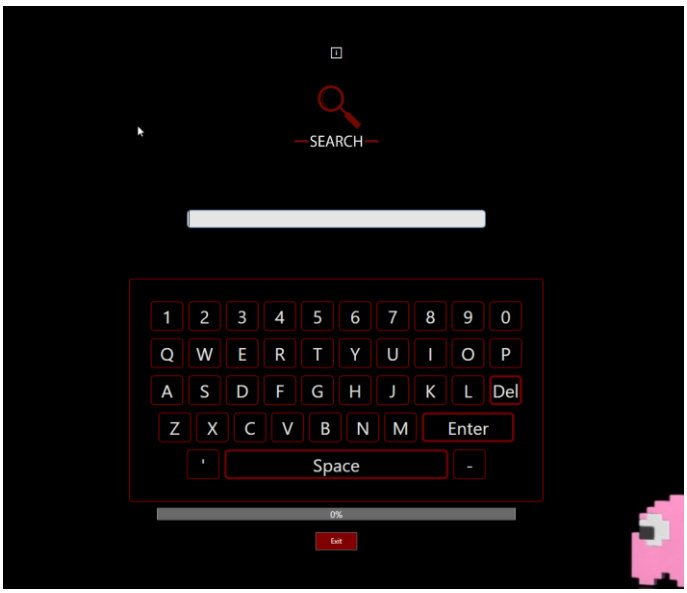
Graphic User Interface to manage all RetroFeVLC Controls

10.1.2 Search

The Search addon provides lightning-fast, integrated game searching capabilities directly within the RetroFeVLC interface. For users with massive game libraries, this tool is indispensable for quickly locating a specific title. When activated, it presents a simple search dialog. If matches are found, RetroFeVLC automatically navigates to a temporary results list. If no matches are found, it asks if you want do another search, and if not, it will flawlessly return you to your previous view.

How It Works





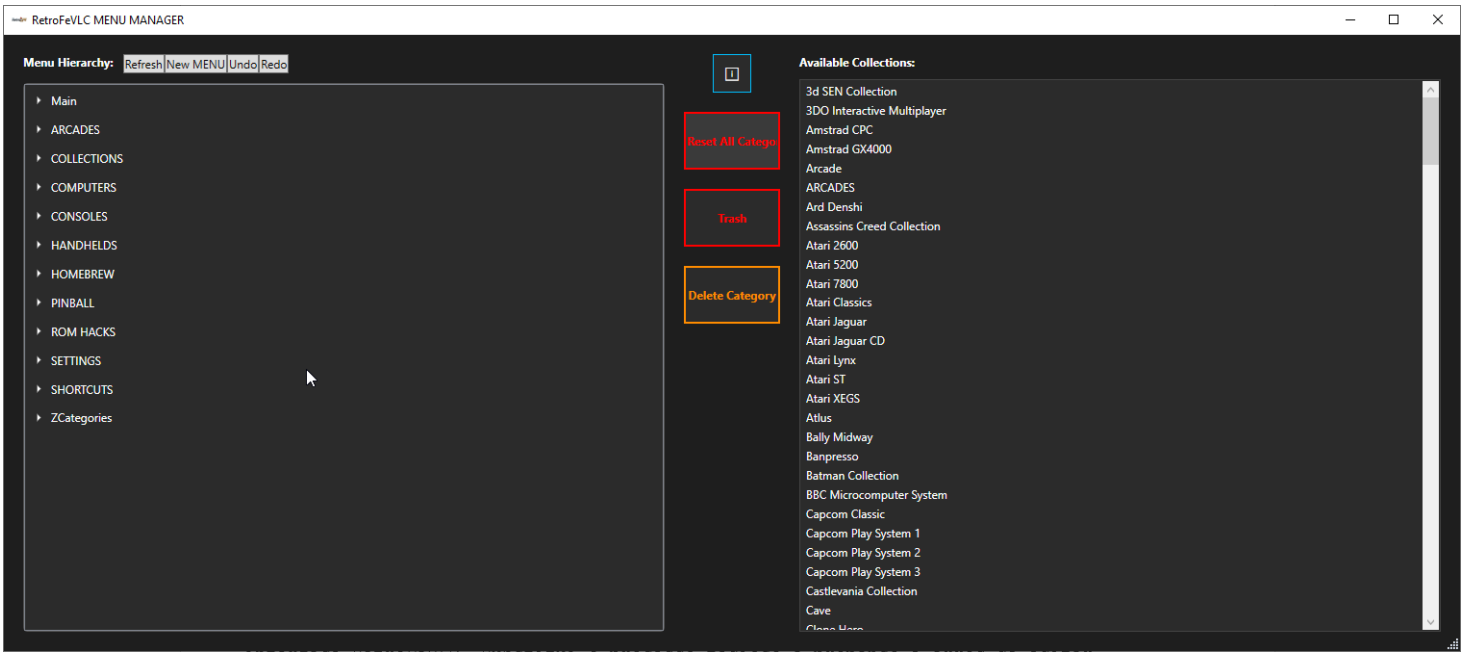
- **Default Hotkey:** The search function is typically bound to the F11 key. This can be easily customized to any key or controller button by using GUI Controls Editing or the controls.conf file to better suit your setup.

- **Search Options:** The addon offers two distinct search modes to narrow down your query:
  - **Search per System:** Allows you to select one or more specific systems (e.g., "Super Nintendo", "Sega Genesis") to search within.
  - **Full Build Search:** Performs a global search across your entire game library at once.

- **Gamepad-Friendly Interface:** The search dialog is designed with arcade cabinets and couch gaming in mind. You can use your gamepad's analog stick or D-pad to control the on-screen mouse cursor and use buttons to select options, use virtual keyboard and confirm your search query.

- **Keyboard Support:** For faster input, the search dialog fully supports direct text entry via a physical keyboard.

10.1.3 MenuManager

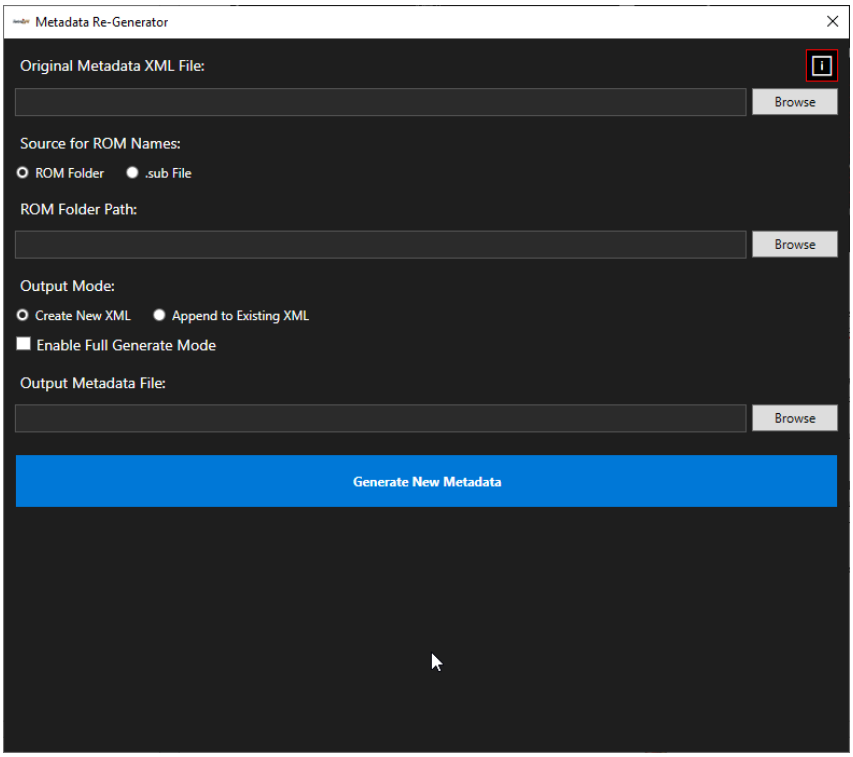


MenuManager is a powerful visual application that revolutionizes how you organize your RetroFeVLC frontend. It replaces the tedious and error-prone process of manually editing text files (\menu\collectionName.txt) with an intuitive, graphical drag-and-drop interface. This tool empowers users to effortlessly build and maintain a clean, logical, and deeply nested menu structure.

Core Capabilities

- **Manage Categories:** Easily create, rename, or delete main menu categories like "Arcades," "Consoles," "Handhelds," and "Computers."
- **Create Submenus:** Build a hierarchical structure by creating nested submenus within any category (e.g., "Consoles" -> "Nintendo" -> "Nintendo 64").
- **Organize Menu Links:** Visually manage the menu/*.txt files that link to your game collections.
- **Manage Custom Collections:** Seamlessly integrate your own custom-made collections into the menu structure.
- **Intuitive Controls:** Reorganize your entire menu by simply dragging items around. The visual feedback makes it easy to understand the structure at a glance.
- **Undo Functionality:** Made a mistake? MenuManager includes an undo feature, allowing you to instantly revert changes without risk.

10.1.4 Metadata Regenerator



The Metadata Regenerator is a specialized tool for creating and customizing metadata XML files, commonly known as "hyperlists." Its primary function is to parse existing large hyperlists and generate new, smaller ones based on specific criteria. This is particularly useful for breaking down monolithic collections into more manageable, themed sub-collections.

Example Use Case: Imagine you have a single Arcades.xml file for MAME containing thousands of games. Using the Metadata Regenerator, you can parse this file and extract only the games belonging to the "Sega System 16" driver, creating a new, dedicated Sega System 16.xml hyperlist.

Key Feature

A significant advantage of using this tool is that it enables a new layout option within RetroFeVLC to display a game count ratio. By having both the master list (e.g., Arcades.xml) and the generated sub-list (e.g., Sega System 16.xml), the frontend can show how many games from the total available are included in your current build (e.g., "MAME: 2000 / 26000").
Allows you to create optimized lists for your collection. Reduce large XML files (for example, from 15MB to 2MB) by filtering only the games you have installed. This makes starting up and searching for the program much more fluid and faster.

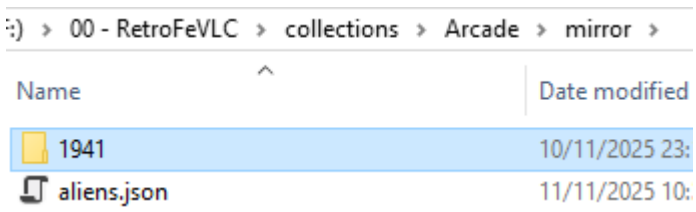
10.1.5 Marquee MonitorDuplicator (ScreenDuplicator)

The Marquee MonitorDuplicator is an innovative addon for users with multi-monitor arcade setups, specifically those with a secondary marquee display. This tool allows you to mirror any portion of your main gameplay screen onto the marquee monitor. It offers complete control over the source and destination areas, allowing you to resize, reposition, and even display multiple mirrored regions simultaneously for a single game.

How it Works
Configuration is handled through a combination of settings files and per-game JSON files.

1. Enable the Addon: First, you must enable the duplicator feature within your main settings.conf file.

2. Create a Mirror Folder: Add a dedicated mirror folder to the collection you wish to configure.



3. Define Mirror Regions: Inside the mirror folder, create JSON files to define the mirror parameters. The configuration specifies the input (source) and output (destination) coordinates (x, y) and dimensions (height, width).

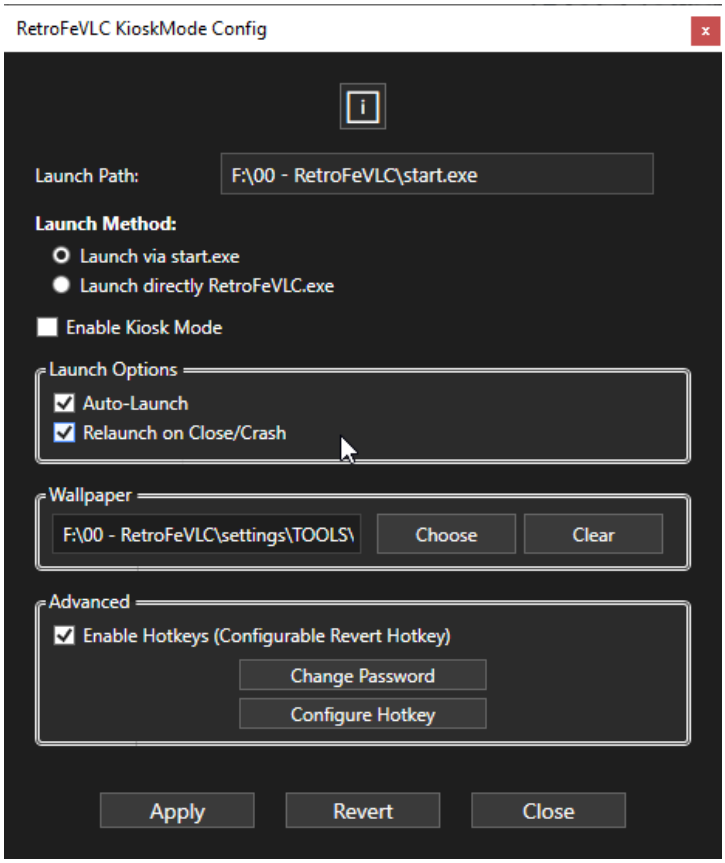
- For a single mirror, create a file named gamename.json.
- For multiple, independent mirrors for the same game, create numbered files like gamename-1.json, gamename-2.json, etc.

aliens.json

```
{
  "X": 881,
  "Y": 17,
  "W": 1002,
  "H": 137,
  "WinX": 670,
  "WinY": -1072,
  "WinW": 1176,
  "WinH": 122,
  "Screen": 2,
  "Refresh": 16,
  "BorderRadius": 15,
  "GameExeName": "arcade64.exe"
}
```

10.1.6 SimpleKioskMode

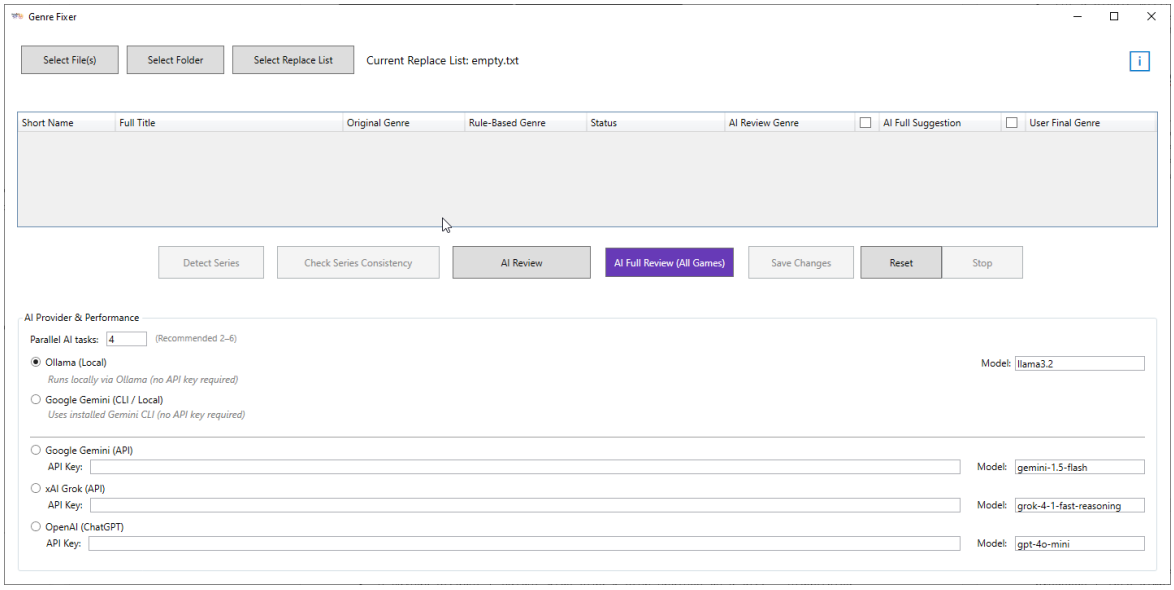
SimpleKioskMode is a utility designed to transform your PC into a dedicated, secure kiosk. It effectively locks down the Windows Shell, preventing users from accessing the underlying operating system, and ensures that your chosen application RetroFeVLC is always running. This is ideal for public arcade cabinets, museum exhibits, or for creating a pure, immersive retro gaming environment at home.



Primary Features

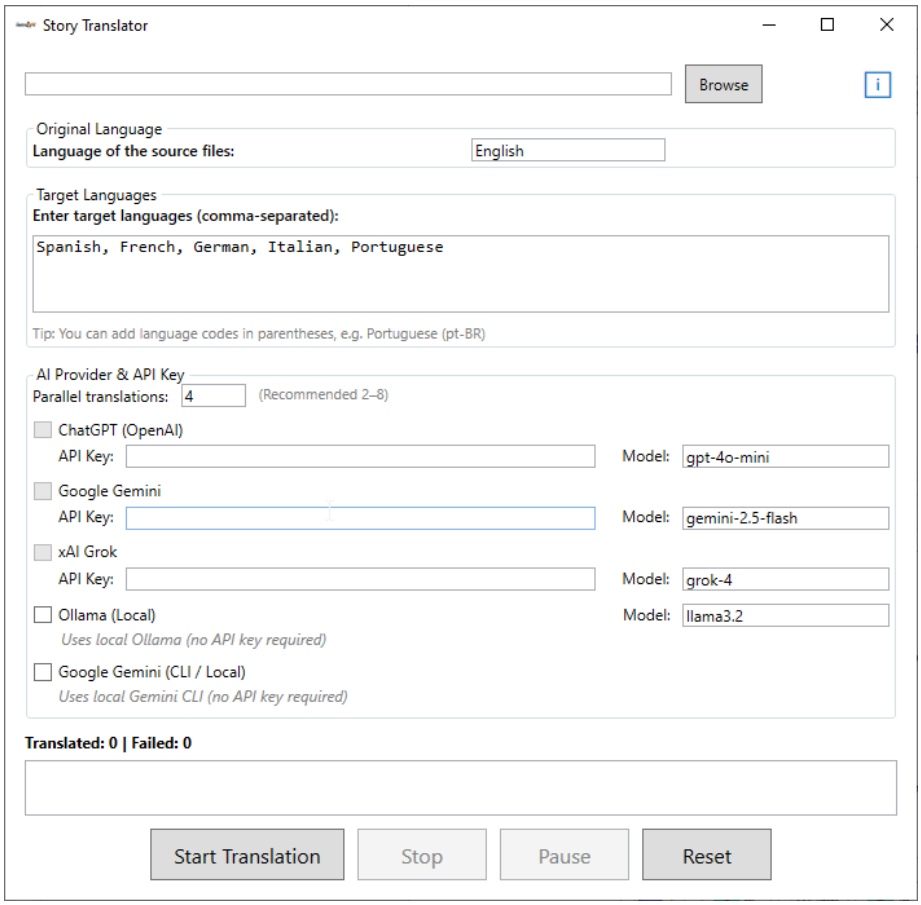
- ☑ **Locks the Shell:** Replaces the standard Windows Explorer Shell, preventing access to the desktop, start menu, and taskbar for a distraction-free experience.
- ☑ **Auto-Launch and Relaunch:** Automatically launches your specified application on startup. If the application is closed or crashes, KioskMode will automatically relaunch it.
- ☑ **Secure Exit:** Exiting KioskMode requires a specific hotkey combination (Ctrl+Alt+C) followed by a password, ensuring unauthorized users cannot bypass it.
- ☑ **Simple Configuration:** Provides a straightforward user interface for setting the application path, changing the exit password, and toggling features. It also includes logging for easy troubleshooting.

10.1.7 Genre Fixer



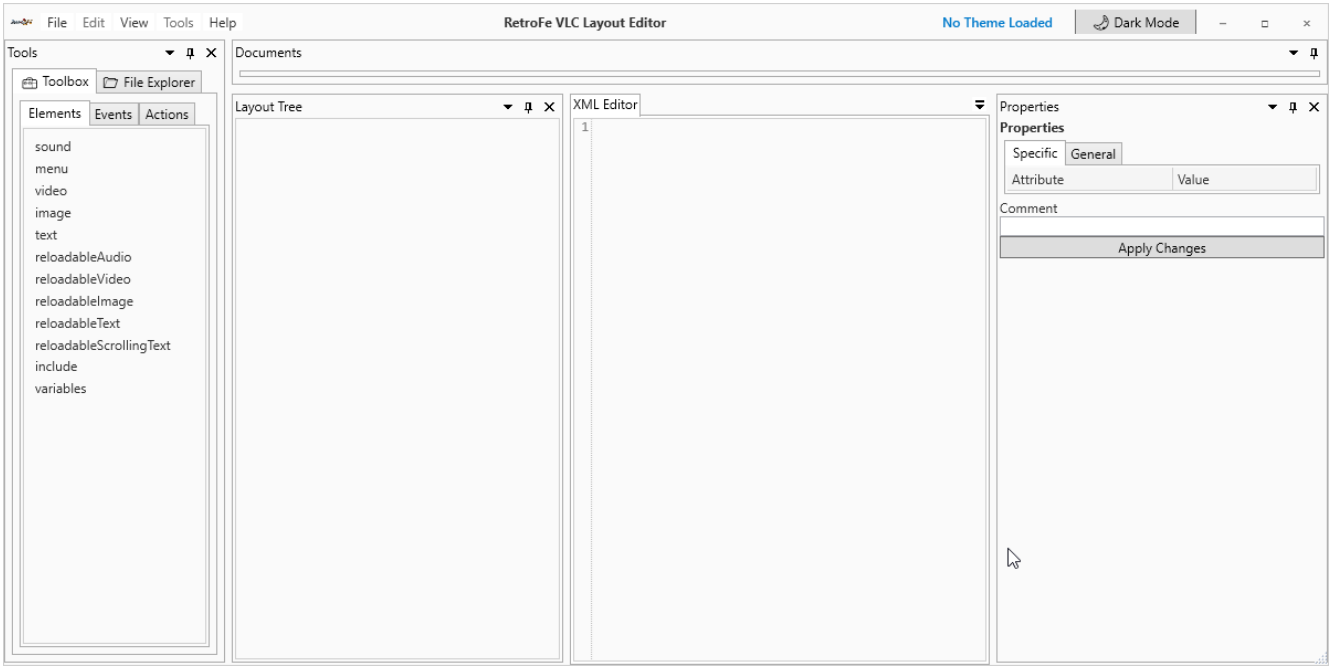
- Automatically fixes all Genres from a Metadata file using AI

10.1.8 Story Translator



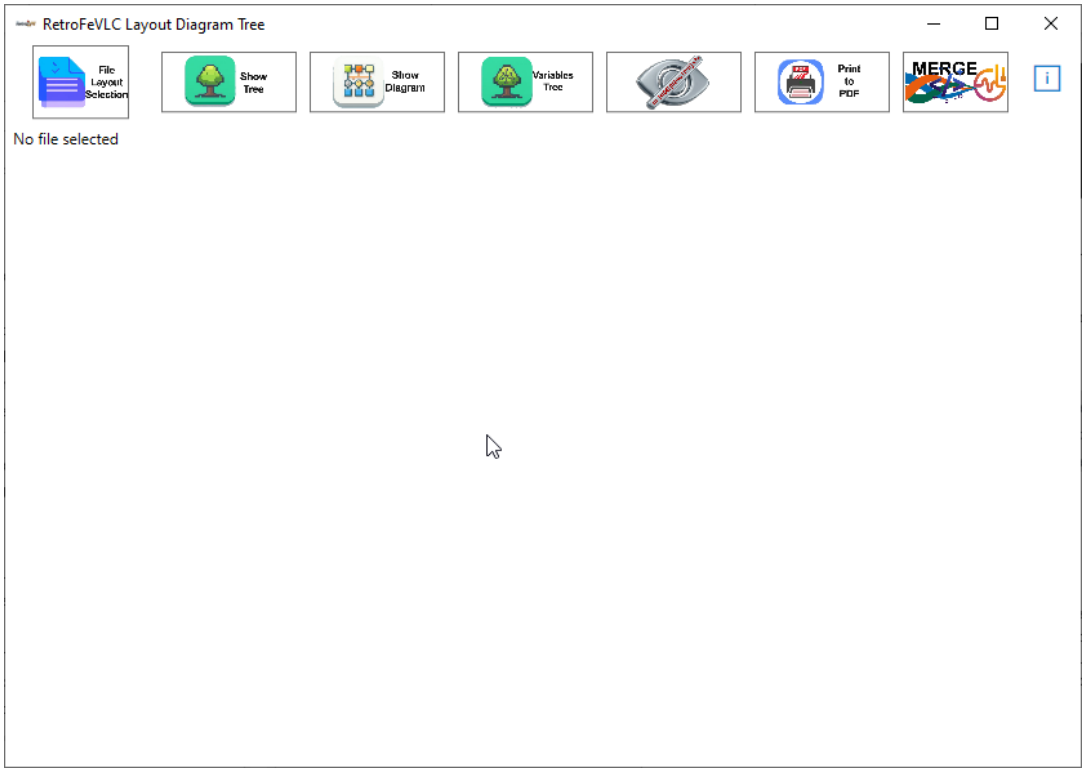
- Automatically translates a selected folder like \medium_artwork\story\ to a selected language(s) using AI.

10.1.9 Layout Editor



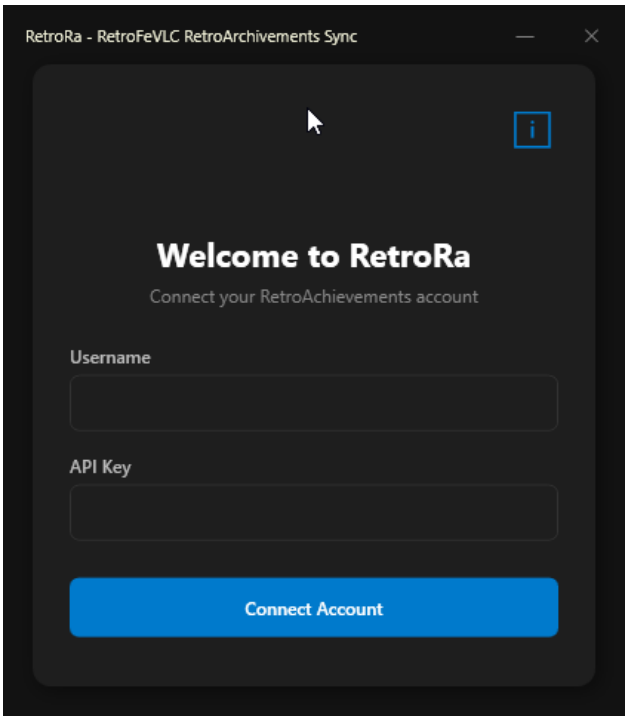
- A Layout Creator / Editor with Drag & Drop options to a tree – organizing everything, avoiding spelling and structural errors.

10.1.10 Layout Tree Maker



- It's an addon that complements the Layout Editor, Useful for more complex layouts with many variables and more complex include structures.

10.1.11 **RetroRa** - RetroAchievements Sync



- Automatically exports your RetroAchievements progress (unlocks, %, points, dates, rich presence…) into simple GameName.conf files per game. Perfect for displaying completion stats, badges, mastery dates and recent activity directly in your arcade frontend.

11. Options Menu System

One of the most significant additions in RetroFeVLC is the interactive Options Menu, which allows for on-the-fly configuration of layout choices directly from the frontend.

11.1. The Layout Menu

This menu reads your main layout.xml to provide options for customizing the theme itself. It works by using a set of special attributes on layout elements.

Attribute	Purpose
group	Assigns the element to a top-level category in the options menu (e.g., group="MAIN_MENU").
subgroup	Assigns the element to a sub-category within a group (e.g., subgroup="MENU_STYLE").
name	The display name for the option in the menu (e.g., name="Vertical Wheel").
active	true or false. Determines if the element is currently enabled. This is the value the user toggles.
shared	Links multiple elements. When an option is toggled, other elements with the same `shared` name can be automatically managed.

```
<!-- In layout.xml, these two elements create a toggleable choice in the menu -->

<menu name="Horizontal_Bottom" group="MAIN_MENU" subgroup="MENU" active="true" />
<menu name="Vertical_Left"     group="MAIN_MENU" subgroup="MENU" active="false" />
```

In the Options Menu, under the "MAIN_MENU" group, the user would see two options. Activating "Vertical_Left" would automatically deactivate "Horizontal_Bottom", allowing for easy theme customization without editing XML.

11.2. Styling the Options Menu (layoutmenu.xml)

The appearance of the options menu itself is fully customizable via a separate file, `layoutmenu.xml`. This file lets you define the menu's window size, background, fonts, colors for titles and selection bars, and even provides text strings for localization.

12. About

This Guide celebrates the RetroFeVLC version, bursting with new features!
Why I'm doing it?!

- Just Thoth it's something was missing.

About this project RetroFeVLC:

I'm excited to share some updates I've been working on for RetroFeVLC, a RetroFE Fork. It is an amazing open-source project licensed under GPL3 that I've been tinkering with in my spare time. My goal has been to enhance the program and make it even more enjoyable for users.
My Approach and Intent
I want to be upfront: I'm not a formally trained C++ developer. I'm just a curious enthusiast who enjoys digging into code and trying to make things better. The way I've implemented these changes might not be perfect — in fact, it's probably far from textbook — but it's still led to some significant improvements. I'm not here to claim I'm better than anyone or to step on toes. We're all part of the same community, working to make RetroFE/RetroFeVLC the best it can be.
My aim is to contribute to this project in a positive way, not to spark any conflicts with other developers. I've got a lot of respect for everyone involved in RetroFE.
Thanks for reading.

13. Credits & Thanks

This guide has been created using the main RetroFE documentation — full credit goes to its original creator(s).

A very special thanks to the creator of RetroFE. Without their work and the GPLv3 license, it wouldn't have been possible to fork the project and evolve it into RetroFE VLC.

Additional thanks to **extracoconut** for revising and improving the text.

A special and personal thank you to my family for their support, patience, and understanding during the time I spent working on this project instead of being with them.

And finally, thank you to everyone in the retro gaming community for the inspiration and support.

14. Official Links

Website - https://retrofevlc.eu/
Documentation - https://retrofevlc.infy.uk/
Official Theme - https://github.com/RFSVIEIRA/PHOENIX
Discord - https://discord.gg/2aYRHdUrVf

By: RFSVIEIRA